



MINDFULNESS "HOW" SKILLS – ONE-MINDFULLY

WHAT IS "ONE-MINDFULLY"?



- **One-Mindfully means Being Completely Present in This One Moment**

One-mindfulness is being present for "just this moment" to our lives and to what we are doing. Living one-mindfully is central to all mindfulness practice.

THE PAST IS OVER – it does not exist in the present. We may have thoughts and images of the past in our minds. Strong emotions may come up when we think about the past. We may worry about things we did in the past or things others did. We may wish our pasts were different, or we may wish we were still in the past.

It is important to recognize that these thoughts, images, feelings and wishes are occurring in the present.

The trouble begins when instead of being aware of thinking about the past, we become LOST in the past or in past thinking or imagining. We stop paying attention to what is happening right here and now. Our emotions now may be identical to the emotions we felt in the past, making us think that we are actually living in the past or that the past is living in us.

THE FUTURE HAS NOT COME INTO EXISTENCE - it also does not exist in the present. We may have many thoughts and plans about the future. Intense emotions may come up when we think about the future. We may have worries about the future – sometimes spending endless nights worrying about what is to come. Same as with worries about the past, it is important to remember that our worries about the future are occurring in the present. It is easy to get LOST in ruminating about the future. Living in the present can include planning for the future, however, when we plan we need to be aware that we are doing it (planning as a present-moment activity)

- **One-Mindfulness Means Doing One Thing at a Time**

When we are one-mindful, we do one thing at a time, with awareness. We focus our attention on only ONE activity or thing at a time, bringing the whole person to bear on this thing or activity.

This is similar to the "worry time" skill --- "worry when you are worrying", not at other times when you try to engage in the tasks of the day.



BENEFITS OF ONE-MINDFULNESS – WHY DO IT?



- **The Pain of the Present Moment is Enough Pain for Anyone**

Adding to a painful present moment all the pain from the past and all the pain from the future is too much. It is too much suffering.

Research tells us that mindfulness is an effective treatment for chronic physical pain – one of the reasons for this is that it keeps us in the present. Ruminating about suffering in the past, and dreading

suffering in the future, both increase the pain in the moment. The road to less pain is letting go of past and future pain, and suffering only the pain of the present moment.

- **Multitasking Is Inefficient**

There is now a lot of research on multitasking – contrary to what most people believe, trying to juggle two things at once does not actually save time. On the contrary, it cuts down on the ability to do things quickly.

- **Life, Relationships and Beauty Pass You By**

When you live life mindless of the present, the present whizzes by. We do not experience many of the things we care about. We do not “smell the roses”. The quality of our daily experience is poor when we live mindlessly.

ONE-MINDFULLY – HOW TO DO IT?



- **Be Present to Your Own Experiences**

This is the opposite of avoiding or trying to suppress our present experiences. Allow yourself to be aware of your current experience – your feelings, your sensations, your thoughts, your movements and your actions.

- **Rivet Yourself to NOW**

The next step is to actively focus and maintain awareness of what we are experiencing now, what is happening now, and what we are doing now. This involves letting go of thoughts of the past and the future. We spend a lot of our lives living in the past (which is over), living in the future (which is not yet here) or responding to our concepts and ideas of what reality is rather than what it actually is. The aim of one-mindfulness is to maintain awareness of the moment we are in.

i.e. You are in a meeting and very bored. Instead of sitting and thinking of all the things you would rather be doing, throw yourself into listening. Focus on the present. This can actually stop you from feeling miserable.

i.e. “When you are driving, drive. When you are walking, walk. When you are eating, eat”

- **Do Only One Thing at a Time**

Doing one thing at a time is the opposite of how people usually function. Most people think that if we do several things at once we will accomplish more – this is not true. Have your mind completely on what you are doing at the moment, whether it is a physical or mental activity. Act with undivided attention. The opposites of one-mindfulness are mindlessness (automatic behavior without awareness) and distracted behavior (doing one thing while thinking about or attending to another). Think of examples of times when you were doing two or more things at once. How did it impact your experience and/or performance of the task(s)?

